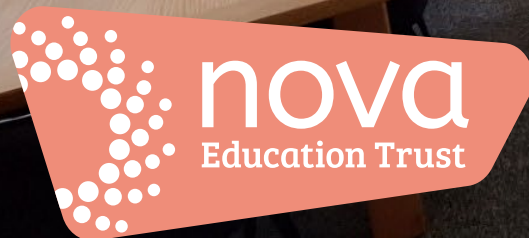


Therapeutic Learning Environment Playbook





Introduction

Across Nova schools we want environments where children feel **calm, safe, and able to learn at their best**. The physical environment of a school plays an important role in this.

Therapeutic classrooms are not specialist spaces for a small number of pupils. They are environments designed so that **all children can regulate, focus and thrive**.

Many classrooms unintentionally create sensory overload through cluttered walls, harsh lighting, busy displays and cramped layouts. For some pupils this becomes a barrier to concentration, confidence and emotional regulation.

Therapeutic environments aim to reduce these barriers by designing spaces that are:

- Calm
- Predictable
- Comfortable
- Purposeful
- Inclusive

When children feel secure and regulated, they are more able to focus on learning, collaborate with others and take pride in their school community.

This approach is therefore not about

decoration. It is about **intentional design** that supports:

- Emotional regulation
- Emotional and psychological safety
- Belonging
- Focus and attention
- Independence
- Pride in the school environment

The guidance below outlines the principles Nova schools should follow when developing therapeutic environments.



Core Principles

Across all environments in school the following principles apply.

1. Intentional design

Every aspect of the environment should have a clear purpose. Spaces should feel calm and organised rather than busy or accidental.

2. Reduced visual overload

Cluttered walls and excessive display can create cognitive overload. Therapeutic classrooms prioritise intentional and purposeful visuals.

3. Neutral and calming colours

Soft, neutral or pastel tones should be used across spaces. These help reduce

overstimulation and create consistency across the school.

4. Comfort and flexibility

Children should have access to seating and spaces that allow them to feel comfortable while still supporting learning.

5. Belonging and identity

Schools should celebrate their community and history in ways that build belonging without creating competition between pupils.

6. Consistency across the school

Whilst individual schools can develop their own identity and colour choices,

there should be internal consistency across the building.

7. High expectations

Therapeutic environments are not relaxed or unstructured spaces. They support strong routines, learning and independence. Whilst allowing for more flexible movement, autonomy and independence in the space at the same time.



Communal Areas

Communal spaces often shape a child's first impression of school and support movement and transition throughout the day.

These areas should feel welcoming, calm and purposeful.

Layout and organisation

Communal spaces should:

- Remain clutter free
- Support clear movement through corridors and shared spaces particularly during transition times.
- Avoid overcrowding with displays or furniture

These spaces should feel open and calm rather than visually overwhelming.

Display and celebration

Communal areas may contain more display than classrooms, but this should still be carefully considered.

Displays may include:

- Curriculum work
- School events
- Wider achievements
- Alumni stories that build a sense of legacy

However, care should be taken that:

- Displays do not compare pupils
- Pupils are not made to feel excluded if their

work is not displayed

- Work shown reflects the current school community or alumni stories

The goal is to build belonging rather than competition.

Framing and presentation

Displays should be presented in ways that maintain a calm aesthetic.

Schools should consider using:

- Photo frames
- Shelving
- Mounted boards
- Neutral backing materials
- Calm lighting
- Calm, neutral colours

These help displays feel intentional and consistent with classroom environments.

Lighting

Lighting has a significant impact on atmosphere as well as concentration and productivity.

Where possible schools should explore:

- Reducing harsh overhead lighting
- Using lamps
- Using soft lighting or fairy lights
- Adjusting lighting systems where possible



The aim is to create warm and calm spaces rather than stark lighting.

Greenery and natural elements

Introducing natural elements can support a calming environment, improving mental health and wellbeing.

Schools may consider:

- Potted plants
- Artificial plants
- Branches or natural materials
- Trailing ivy or foliage

These elements can help bring aspects of the outdoors into the building.

Air flow

Where possible, schools should consider:

- Improving air flow
- Using windows where appropriate
- Creating environments that feel fresh and well ventilated

Breakout spaces

Schools should consider creating small breakout areas or nooks in communal spaces where children can:

- Regulate
- Calm down
- Complete work

- Speak with adults

These spaces should:

- Be safe and secure
- Avoid singling children out
- Include comfortable seating
- Potentially include small desks or work surfaces

Furniture must still comply with relevant safety and seating standards.

Ownership and maintenance

Communal areas often fall between responsibilities.

Schools should ensure:

- Clear ownership of these spaces
- Routines for maintaining them
- High expectations for presentation

These areas should be maintained to the same standard as classrooms.



Classrooms

Classrooms should be designed to support focus, calm and effective learning.

Wall displays

Most traditional classroom displays should be removed or significantly reduced.

Classrooms should avoid:

- Busy topic displays
- Excessive materials on walls and windows
- Visually overwhelming learning walls
- Bright contrasting colours
- Display boards on every wall

Instead classrooms should prioritise:

- Neutral walls
- Minimal displays
- Calm, clear walls behind the classroom screen or board
- 1–3 neutral colours that compliment each other
- Framed items
- Carefully selected visuals, purposeful visuals or prompts

The aim is to create a calm working environment.

Purposeful visuals

Displays may include:

- Key messages

- Reminders
- Working boards
- Inspirational quotes
- Celebration of teamwork or shared moments

Displays should avoid highlighting individual pupils in ways that may impact confidence or belonging.

Storage and organisation

Classrooms should be carefully decluttered.

Items not regularly used should be stored in:

- Cupboards
- Closed shelving
- Labelled storage systems

Every item should have a clear home.

Responsibility for maintaining this organisation sits with the class teacher and adults working in the space.

Storage solutions could also include:

- Baskets
- Caddies
- Well-organised resource trolleys

Seating

Every child should have access to a desk and seat appropriate for their age and size.

However classrooms may also include flexible seating such as:



- Sofas
- Floor seating
- Cushions
- Beanbags
- Different height seating options

These should support comfort and meet different learning needs without disrupting learning routines.

Floor seating

Some pupils may work effectively while:

- Sitting on the floor
- Lying on their stomach
- Using cushions or mats

This can support comfort, meeting different learning preferences support and core strength development during writing.

Lighting

Classrooms should avoid harsh lighting where possible.

Schools should explore:

- Lamps
- Soft lighting
- Adjusting overhead lighting use
- Careful use of blinds and curtains

This also helps prevent glare on screens and boards. Remember to make use of natural daylight as much

as possible. This promotes positive wellbeing and boosts alertness and productivity.

Classroom responsibility

Children should be encouraged to take responsibility for maintaining their classroom environment.

This may include:

- Classroom roles
- Care of furniture
- Tidying routines
- Maintaining calm environments

Some schools may also explore options such as:

- Removing shoes
- Using slippers

Where this supports comfort and cleanliness.



SEMH and Enhanced Provision Spaces

Enhanced provision or SEMH environments should follow the same principles as classrooms but with additional considerations.

These spaces should prioritise:

- Regulation
- Independence
- Safety
- Access to learning

Space and layout

Enhanced provision spaces should avoid becoming cramped.

Schools should ensure:

- Adequate space for movement
- Clear areas for learning
- Calm regulation spaces

These spaces should generally have more space available than a typical classroom.

Regulation spaces

Provision should include access to areas that support emotional regulation.

This may include:

- Sensory spaces
- Quiet areas
- Soft seating
- Calming lighting

However, these spaces must still support access to learning.

Access to learning resources

Children should still have access to:

- Literacy resources
- Maths resources
- Concrete materials
- Writing equipment
- Independent learning tools

This ensures children in these spaces continue developing core academic skills.

Outdoor access

Where possible, spaces should provide access to:

- Outdoor space
- Fresh air
- Natural environments
- Play

Outdoor access can be particularly important for regulation and a positive sense of wellbeing.

Lighting

Lighting should be carefully considered and may include:

- Softer lighting
- Blackout blinds
- Sensory lighting options



Implementation Across Nova Schools

Each Nova school will develop its own therapeutic environment in line with these principles.

Schools should:

- Work with the trust central team to overcome barriers
- Develop a consistent approach within their own building
- Ensure all furniture meets relevant safety and seating standards

While the trust provides principles and guidance, implementation should allow for **local identity and ownership**.

Schools may therefore:

- Choose their own colour schemes
- Select furniture and materials
- Design environments that reflect their community

However, all decisions should be **intentional and aligned with the therapeutic principles outlined in this document**.

“Beautiful buildings are visible symbols of a community’s commitment to children. Schools and libraries, built to last, with attention to detail and aesthetics, tell a child that he or she is important, and that the work that goes on in that building is important.”

Ron Berger, 2003

An Ethic of Excellence: Building a Culture of Craftsmanship with Students



**therapeutic
classrooms**

